I chose Task A and fine-tuned *whisper-tiny* and *whisper-small* on German Common Voice (CV). I picked Whisper over wav2vec2 for contamination reasons: most German wav2vec2 checkpoints are already fine-tuned on CV, so held-out test data can sit inside the baseline. Whisper was not trained on CV specifically (though I cannot rule out its web-scrape). Running two sizes of the same family let me test the hypothesis that gains from fine-tuning shrink as the base model gets stronger. ***Tiny* went from 46.9% to 33.7% WER, *small* from 15.3% to 13.1% WER**, both statistically significant (paired bootstrap, neither CI (confidence interval) includes zero). Table and normalization rules are in the README.

My key data decision was to use the official CV train/dev/test splits unmodified because they guarantee no speaker and no sentence appears in more than one split, which I verified programmatically rather than trusting it directly. I then created fixed subsets (10k train/1k dev/1k test) with committed audio-clip IDs so that every run uses identical data. The test set is touched twice per model: once before fine-tuning, once after, with identical decoding and normalization. Moreover, CV left HF in late 2025; rather than trust an unofficial mirror I pulled the official Mozilla release and read its terms, which forbid re-sharing the audio. I treated provenance and usage rights as part of the task. So the repo ships no audio, only raw model outputs and reference texts, which reproduce all my results on CPU via run_eval.py.

The thing I changed after seeing it fail was my training schedule: planned 1500 steps for both models, then switched to training each to its own dev plateau. *Tiny's* WER on dev stopped improving after step 1000, so I kept that checkpoint. *Small*'s first attempt crashed before completing (laptop died), but it already showed WER flat from step 500 to 1000 with validation loss rising, so I did the rerun with 500. Something that did not help was number normalization (spelling out digits because num2words reads the German years wrong). It shifts WER only 0.3 points, since apparently only 43 of 1000 test references contain digits, and the models learned to spell numbers out anyway.

The number I do not fully trust is *tiny*'s 13.2-point improvement. Its bootstrap CI came out suspiciously wide, so I inspected per-clip errors: on two clips the base model got stuck in repetition loops, producing 440 and 177 errors against references of 10 and 13 words. With loop clips excluded, the improvement is 8.3 points with a tight CI, which still supports the hypothesis but not as strongly. Fine-tuning removed both loops but introduced one new, milder one, so it reduced this failure mode without eliminating it. In a clinical setting this is the failure I would worry about most: the model invents fluent text instead of failing visibly, and average error rates hide it unless you inspect more closely. The weakest part overall is domain: I measured gains on the CV dataset, which is Wikipedia-style sentences read out loud; not spontaneous, conversational, clinical speech. So I would not assume that the improvement transfers to the clinical domain without measuring it.